

THE LITTLE WATER SNAKE

Hydrus



BRIGHTEST ST
Beta (β) 2.8

GENITIVE Hydri

ABBREVIATION Hvi

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
October–December

FULLY VISIBLE
8°N–90°S



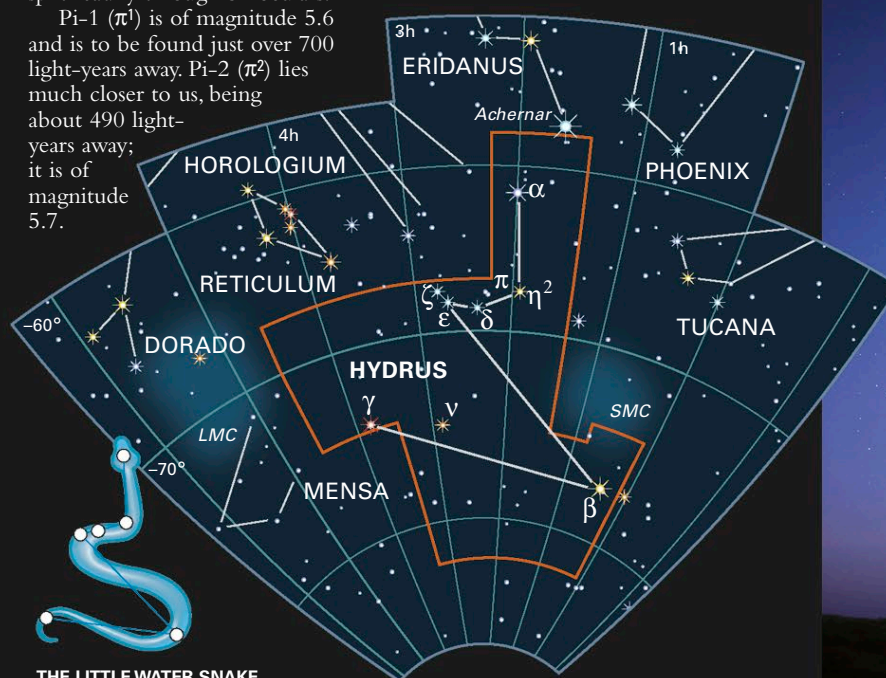
Hydrus was introduced in the late 16th century by the Dutch navigator–astronomers Pieter Dirkszoon Keyser and Frederick de Houtman (see p.416). It is a constellation of the far-southern sky and is situated between the Large Magellanic Cloud (see p.310) and the Small Magellanic Cloud (see p.311).

This constellation represents a small water snake. It should not be confused with the larger constellation Hydra, also identified as a water snake, which has been recognized since the time of the ancient Greeks.

SPECIFIC FEATURES

Pi (π) Hydri is a wide double of 6th-magnitude red giants, although they lie at different distances from us and hence are unrelated. It can be split readily through binoculars.

Pi-1 (π^1) is of magnitude 5.6 and is to be found just over 700 light-years away. Pi-2 (π^2) lies much closer to us, being about 490 light-years away; it is of magnitude 5.7.



THE PENDULUM CLOCK

Horologium



BRIGHTEST STAR
Alpha (α) 3.9

GENITIVE Horologii

ABBREVIATION Hor

HIGHEST IN SKY AT 10 P.M.
November–December

FULLY VISIBLE
23°N–90°S



Horologium represents a pendulum clock, as used in observatories. Some depictions show its brightest star, Alpha (α) Horologii, marking the clock's pendulum (as in the illustration here), while others include it as one of the clock weights.

This faint and unremarkable constellation of the southern sky lies near the foot of Eridanus and was introduced by the French astronomer Nicolas Louis de Lacaille (see p.422).

SPECIFIC FEATURES

R Horologii is a red-giant variable star of the same type as Mira (in Cetus). It ranges between 5th and 14th magnitudes every 13 months or so.



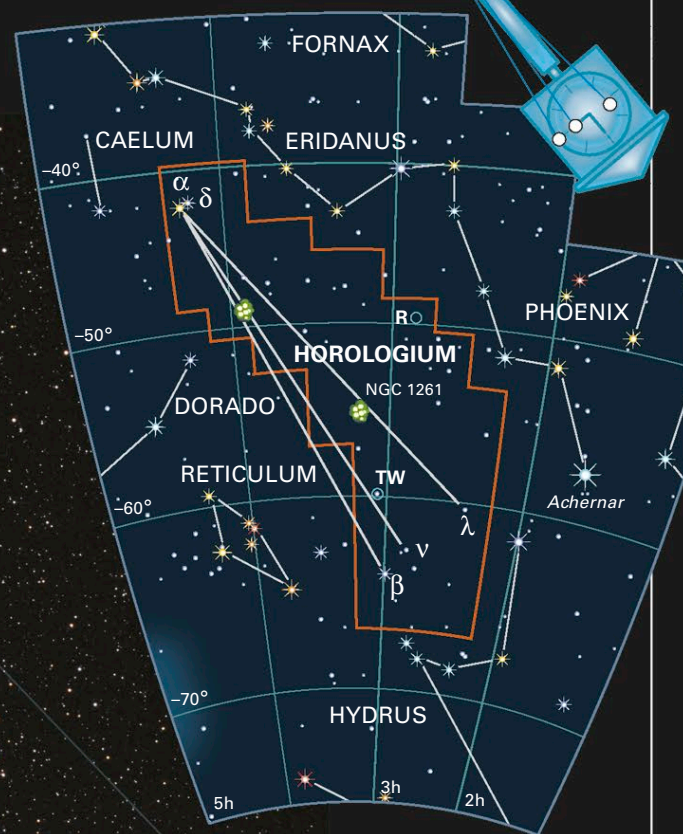
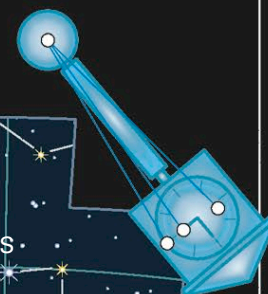
NGC 1261 🔭 📖

The best deep-sky object in Horologium for amateur instruments is NGC 1261, a compact globular cluster of 8th magnitude more than 50,000 light-years from us.

HYDRUS AND ACHEARNAR

The sinuous little water snake winds its way across southern skies between the two Magellanic Clouds. The brightest star near it is Achernar in Eridanus (top, right.)

THE PENDULUM CLOCK



STELLAR CLOCK  The shape of Horologium is reminiscent of a clock with a long pendulum—unlike many of the shapeless constellations invented by de Laaille.